

Yifan (Kristoff) Cao

5514 S Blackstone Ave Apt 104, Chicago, IL 60637

Telephone: (+1) 507-581-7624

E-mail: kristoff0366@gmail.com

Education

University of Chicago, Master of Arts, 2026

Master of Arts Program in the Social Sciences

Concentration: Quantitative Methods and Social Analysis (QMSA)

Thesis title: Grassroots Infrastructural Power and Local Policy Responsiveness under Campaign-Style Governance in China

Advisor: Dali Yang

Carleton College, Bachelor of Arts, 2025

Dual degree in Political Science and Mathematics

Thesis title (Political Science): Autocracy under Disasters: Responsive Authoritarianism During Disaster Relief

Advisor: Huan Gao

Thesis title (Mathematics): Lie Groups and Their Application to Ordinary Differential Equations

Advisors: Rob Thompson and Sunrose Shrestha

Cum Laude

Affiliations

Fellow, Chicago Center on Democracy (University of Chicago), Dec 2025 – Present

A student fellow for the Center directed by Prof. Susan Stokes (Chair, American Political Science Association); engaged in peer seminars and research discussions regarding democratic participation and backsliding

Academic Awards

Chang-Lan Fellowship, Carleton College, May 2023 – May 2024

Funding supports field work in China (with Richard Liu '25) that investigates how China's Zero-COVID policy was implemented on a grassroots level, focusing on street-level governments' (residential committees') experience

Conference Presentations

"The Zero-COVID Policy and Grassroots Urban Governance: Rethinking China's Bureaucracy and Campaign-style Mobilization," Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Annual Conference, Chicago, IL, April 6, 2025

Publications

Cao, Kristoff. “Domestic Politics and Transnational Repression: Evidence from a Zero-Inflated Poisson Model.” *Undergraduate Journal of Humanistic Studies* (Carleton College), vol. 19, Spring 2026. <https://www.carleton.edu/ujhs/>

Replicated a large-N analysis on domestic determinants of transnational repression; proposed and executed methodological extension by fitting a Zero-inflated Poisson Model; uncovered significant statistical results and suggested possible pathways for future theory-building

Working Papers

Grassroots Infrastructural Power and Local Policy Responsiveness under Campaign-Style Governance in China (University of Chicago), Mar 2026 – Present

Develops a theory of variation in campaign-style governance across subnational units in China; argues that grassroots infrastructural power conditions the intensity of local policy implementation; constructs a novel subnational panel dataset combining neighborhood committee data with OxCGRT policy indicators; conducts an empirical test of variation in Zero-COVID policy responses (2020–2022) via a set of hierarchical mixed effect models

Teaching and Tutoring Experience

Private AP Statistics/ AP Calculus (AB) Instructor, Bridge Consulting for Education (Remote), Sep 2026 – Present

Deliver one-on-one remote instruction over Zoom, 2–4 hours per week, preparing a student for the AP Statistics and AP Calculus AB exams in May 2027

Private Economics Instructor, Bridge Consulting for Education (Remote), Oct 2025 – Present

Designed a fully customized AP-level Economics curriculum for an Australian student tailored to the student’s specific intellectual interests beyond standard requirements
Delivered one-on-one remote lectures covering advanced Micro- and Macroeconomic theory

English Language Instructor, Bridge Consulting for Education, Suzhou, China, Jun–Aug 2024 & Jun–Aug 2025

Designed and taught lessons focused on test strategies, critical thinking, and effective communication for international school students preparing for standardized English exams
Courses Taught: IELTS Speaking and Writing, TOEFL Reading and Listening

Peer Tutor, Carleton Math & Stats Skills Center, Sep 2022 – June 2025

Led walk-in tutoring sessions on a wide range of courses including Calculus I–III, Linear Algebra, ODEs, PDEs, Probability, Statistical Inferences, Mathematical Structures, Real Analysis I, Abstract Algebra, and more

Course Grader, Carleton Math & Stats Department, Sep 2022 – June 2025

Graded course assignments and provided weekly feedback to faculty for courses including Multivariable Calculus, Applied Regression Analysis, and Introduction to Statistical Inference

Professional Research Experience

Research Assistant, Civic Participation in China Survey (CPCS), Sep 2026 – Present
Supervisor: Jessica C. Teets (Political Science, Middlebury College)

Clean, code, and harmonize the fifth wave (2026) of a five-wave online survey of urban Chinese residents run by a five-member team at the University of Alberta, the London School of Economics, Colgate University, Western Sydney University, and Middlebury College. Conduct exploratory and statistical analysis of philanthropic behavior, state-led and citizen-led volunteering, social trust, and perceptions of citizenship, and support Prof. Carolyn L. Hsu in preparing a conference paper for November 2026.

Research Associate, Department of Political Science, University of Chicago, Aug 2026 – Dec 2026

Supervisor: Dali Yang (Political Science, University of Chicago)

Supports research on political attitudes before/after the COVID pandemic; cleans and conducts statistical analysis using the Chinese General Social Survey (CGSS) data

Political Science Field Research, Carleton College, Jul 2023 – Aug 2023

Advisor: Huan Gao (Political Science, Carleton College)

Conducted fieldwork regarding Zero-COVID policy in China for a month; administered semi-structured interviews with a sub-district government official and 8 neighborhood committee employees; presented preliminary findings at the Carleton Undergraduate Research Symposium

Zero-COVID Policy Data Project Research Assistant, Carleton College, Dec 2022 – Jan 2023

Advisor: Huan Gao (Political Science, Carleton College)

Collaborated on data collection regarding implementation of China's Zero-COVID policy via archiving official WeChat posts from randomly sampled subdistrict governments in Shanghai (Apr–Dec 2022); analyzed state propaganda and enforcement patterns at the neighborhood level

Statistical Consulting for Northfield Public High School, Carleton College, Sep 2022 – Nov 2022

Supervisor: Andy Poppick (Mathematics & Statistics, Carleton College)

Cleaned and analyzed 5 years of ACT performance data using R; built hierarchical mixed effects model to diagnose student weaknesses by subdomain and subject and probe how COVID-19 impacted academic performance of students from different racial, gender, and

socioeconomic backgrounds; delivered evidence-based recommendations for instructional improvements

Methodological Training

- Causal Inference: Generalized DiD design, instrumental variable, regression discontinuity design
- Advanced Quantitative Methods: Causal inference with modern machine learning methods, policy evaluation, semi-parametric efficient estimation, formal (game) theory
- Statistical Theory and Empirical Methods: Asymptotic theory, statistical inference, generalized linear models, hierarchical mixed-effect models, time series models, spatial models
- Pure Mathematics: Measure-theoretic probability, real analysis, abstract algebra, advanced linear algebra, partial and ordinary differential equations, elementary algebraic geometry, mathematical proofs
- Programming and Computational Software: R (advanced), Stata (proficient), LaTeX (advanced), Python (basic), Mathematica (proficient), MATLAB (proficient), NetLogo (basic)

Languages

Mandarin (native), Suzhou dialect (advanced), English (superior)